



AGAINST THE TIDE: Bhandari with some of her students

The Enabling Educator

A unique hostel in Rajasthan is motivating and helping the physically challenged to get higher education

■ **By Rohit Parihar**

Bhanwar Lal, 32, was a puncture repairman before a tyre burst blinded him for life in 1997. Life would have taken a different turn had he not enrolled for a graduate course, facilitated by Pragya Niketan, a unique hostel. Today, Lal is pursuing a B.Ed degree. His story is one from a treasure trove of success stories encrypted on the walls of Pragya Niketan. The hostel was established in 1999 in Jodhpur, and has changed the lives of many who could never think beyond crafting furniture or hawking at bus stands. Today, they have masters degrees, even doctorates, in subjects like political science and management.

"We must aim at rehabilitating the severely handicapped through higher education. They should not be handicapped by means or resources," says its 52-year-old founder Kusum Bhandari. Visually impaired and physically challenged students are admitted here after completing school, motivated and helped to pursue higher education.

In fact, Bhandari's own life inspired her to cement the foundation of the institution. The beginning came in 1959 when polio paralysed Bhandari for life. "People will break her will to live," doctors told her parents then. These words later became the motivation for her family and there was



no stopping her from attending college, where at the age of 23, she got a lecturer's position. As social organisations began inviting her to address the physically challenged, Bhandari got the opportunity to interact with such students, motivating them to get into colleges. Subsequently, she demanded an exclusive hostel for male students and it was only in 2005 that the Jainarain Vyas University in Jodhpur agreed to give her an abandoned structure.

The institute now has 80 resident students, 60 of whom are visually impaired. The average expenditure on each student is about Rs 18,000 per year, which is met by the support received from charitable trusts and individual donors. In the last nine years, 50 of the 150 inmates have graduated from various colleges and secured Government jobs.

Struggling to buy a mini-bus and software that helps read out text to the visually impaired, Bhandari still finds it beyond her capacity to begin a hostel for girls. A beginning been made, however. Bhandari provides special facilities and a Rs 1,500 annual scholarship to deserving female students. As Sunil Arora, principal secretary to the Rajasthan chief minister, recalls Bhandari's struggle to ensure increased remuneration for examiners supervising the visually impaired, "Not many can fight through the system the way she has." Not many will disagree. ■